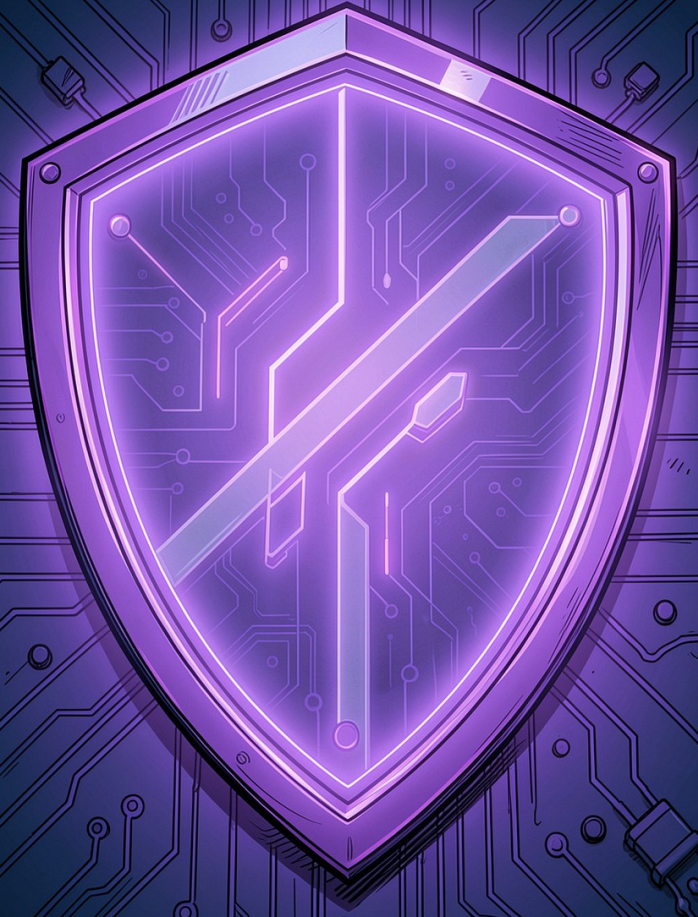


Cybersecurity 101: Protect Yourself Online

A beginner's guide to staying safe in the digital world.





What is Cybersecurity?

Protect Your Digital World

Cybersecurity is the practice of protecting computers, networks, and data from digital attacks — keeping your personal information safe.

What Hackers Are After

Hackers try to steal information, money, or cause damage — targeting anyone from individuals to large companies.

Why It Matters to You

Everyone — students, workers, families — needs basic cybersecurity knowledge to stay safe online.

Meet the Hackers



■ White Hat

The Good Guys. Ethical hackers hired to find security holes legally — protecting systems before criminals can strike.



■ Black Hat

The Bad Guys. Criminals who hack for personal gain — stealing data, money, and identities, breaking laws along the way.



♥ Grey Hat

The In-Between. Mixed motives — may find vulnerabilities without permission, then report them. Not always illegal, but ethically questionable.

BLACK HAT

Meet the Hackers: Black Hat



These are the **criminals of the digital world** — hacking purely for personal gain with no regard for the damage they cause.

- **The Bad Guys:** They break into systems illegally to profit at your expense
- Steal data, money, and identities from real people and businesses
- Break laws and cause serious, lasting harm to their victims

⊗ Black hat attacks are crimes — victims can lose thousands of dollars and years rebuilding their identity.

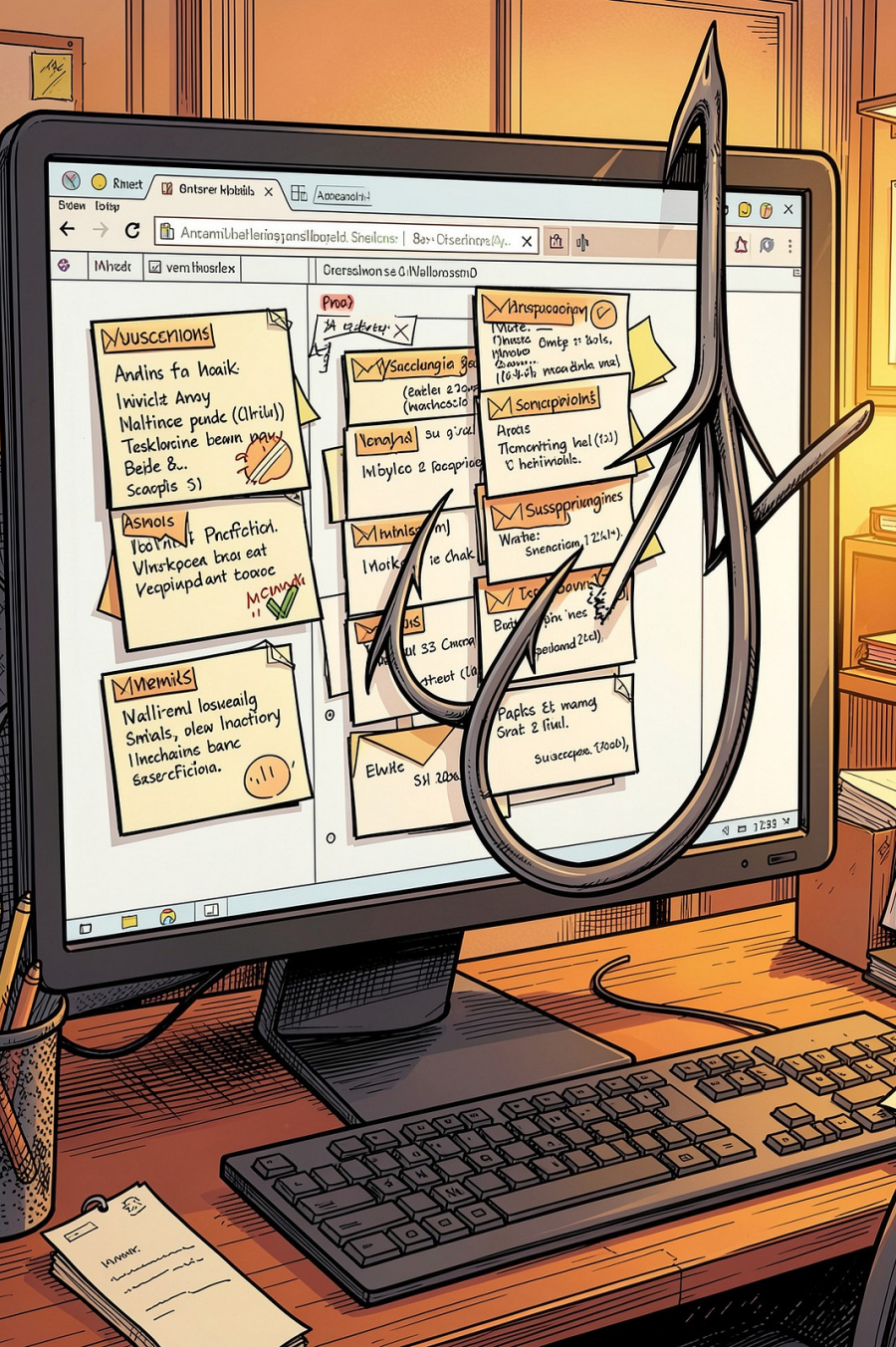
GREY HAT

Meet the Hackers: Grey Hat

Not quite good, not quite bad — grey hat hackers operate in a **murky ethical middle ground** that keeps everyone guessing.

- **The In-Between:** Mixed motives drive their actions — sometimes helpful, sometimes not
- May find vulnerabilities in systems *without permission*, then report them afterwards
- Not always illegal — but definitely ethically questionable territory





Phishing: The Fake Email Trap

How It Works

Attackers send fake emails pretending to be your bank, a delivery company, or even your boss.

The Danger

Links or attachments contain malware — or trick you into handing over your login info and passwords.

Stay Safe

Check the sender's email address, hover over links before clicking, and never open suspicious attachments.

Trojans: The Hidden Threat 🐎

Like the legendary Trojan Horse, this malware **disguises itself as something harmless** — then strikes from the inside.

- Malware disguised as legitimate software, games, or files you'd actually want
- Once installed, it gives hackers **secret access** to your computer without you knowing
- **Stay safe:** Only download from official sources, and always use antivirus software



Other Common Threats You Should Know



Ransomware 💰

Malicious software that **locks all your files** and demands a payment before you can get them back. Businesses and hospitals are frequent targets.



Malware 🦠

A broad category of **harmful software** — viruses, spyware, worms — designed to damage your device or steal your data quietly in the background.



Weak Passwords 🔑

Simple passwords like "123456" or "password" are **laughably easy for hackers to crack** — giving them instant access to your accounts.

Your Defense Toolkit

Two-Factor Auth

Add a second verification step for accounts.

Keep Software Updated

Apply patches promptly to close vulnerabilities.

Strong Passwords

Use unique mixes of letters, numbers, symbols.

Antivirus & Firewall

Block and detect threats before they reach you.

These four habits form your **core defense** against the vast majority of cyberattacks targeting everyday users.



Stay Cyber-Safe: Your Action Plan

1

Think Before You Click

Always verify the sender and hover over links — if something feels off, trust your gut and don't click.

2

Guard Your Passwords

Never share passwords or personal information online — no legitimate company will ever ask for them.

3

Back Up Your Files

Regularly back up important documents so that ransomware or crashes can never hold you hostage.

4

Report Suspicious Activity

Spotted something suspicious? Report it to authorities or your IT team — you could protect someone else too.